down my government, Herzog, has said that there is no daylight between us when it comes to the deal with Iran," he said.

They didn't change their tone until the deal was done. Lapid launched a broadside on 20 September, weeks after Obama secured passage of the agreement in Congress. He said the prime minister had failed because he couldn't "read the map" and understand a changing America. "He has lost by knockout," the former finance minister concluded, calling the vote "Israel's biggest foreign policy failure."

All of this was widely interpreted to mean that Israelis were united in opposition to the deal. The truth was that Israel never bothered to debate it. There were certainly reasons for skepticism. Iran, with a well-documented history of hiding its nuclear facilities, could cheat: the agreement did nothing to limit its aggressive role in the region, nor did it stop Iran from enriching uranium. But there were also reasons to support it, none of which filtered into the public discourse.

"I know Herzog very well, I have high regard for his intellectual capabilities," Halevy said. "I think on the Iranian issue, he should have taken a different stance. But suddenly it became almost unpatriotic to be not together. Netanyahu has been very successful at putting down the line: if you're not speaking the way I'm speaking… you are deviating from the interests of the state of Israel."

With politicians eying the next election, the task of promoting the pact fell to the retired leaders of Israel's security services. Dozens of them signed an open letter in *Ha'aretz* in August, urging Netanyahu to accept the deal as an "accomplished fact" and work with Washington to implement it. There was, to be sure, a degree of tokenism in the effort. Among the best-known signatories was Ami Ayalon, a former Shin Bet director who traveled to America to urge lawmakers to support the deal (and who harbors a grudge against Netanyahu dating back to the tunnel riots). His agency, however, is tasked with domestic security—keeping track of Palestinian militants, not Iranian centrifuges. Other signatories included an ex-police commissioner and the one-time head of the fire brigade, neither of them noted experts on the nuclear fuel cycle.

Halevy was somewhat harder to dismiss. So was Uzi Eilam, a former director of Israel's atomic energy commission. "I'm a bit different because I'm actually familiar with the technology," he joked.